Though they were eclipsed and even reabsorbed into Hinduism, both Jainism and Buddhism had a lasting impact on the religion they had sought to transform. Buddhist monasticism led to the establishment of the concept of *sannyasi*s (monks or ascetics) in Hinduism—who, inspired by the Buddhists, wear ochre robes, shave their heads and practise celibacy for life. (There was no pre-Buddhist equivalent of this: Hindu priests were *grihasthas*, married householders, and not *sannyasis)*. Similarly the Buddhist monasteries prompted Sankaracharya to establish *mutth*s, in which *sannyasi*s and lay students could live together and learn in a sort of *gurukul* (or traditional school). As to Jainism, the acceptance of *ahimsa* as a basic principle in Hinduism was clearly a response to Mahavira Jaina's emphasis on this doctrine. The adoption of vegetarianism as a superior form of life by a large number of Hindus, especially Brahmins, is also a Jain contribution to Hinduism.

Hinduism reasserted itself in response to the rise of Buddhism and Jainism, largely supplanting or absorbing these faiths across the country, to the extent that the practice of Buddhism largely ended (so much so that that until the 1950s, the Buddha in Sarnath sported a Vaishnava namam, or holy mark on his forehead), and the Jains began to be regarded by a section of Hindus as a sort of Hindu sect (though many Jains disputed this) rather than as a rival faith. By the tenth century, Hinduism had reasserted its dominance, swallowed up its reformers, reformulated its popular doctrines, equipped itself with a higher philosophy which found acceptance among the intellectuals, accommodated popular forms of idol worship, created major spiritual centres and furnished itself with *sannyasi*s to spread the word. Its supremacy in India seemed incontestable.

But around 1000 CE a new challenge arose from the northwest to the dominance of Hinduism in the subcontinent. The raids into India by Mohammed bin Qasim, who invaded Sind in 712 CE, Mahmud of Ghazni (who attacked India seventeen times between 1000 CE and 1027 CE) and Muhammad Ghori (who launched several bloody raids between the 1180s and the 1220s), among others, took many lives, destroyed much property and left deep scars. Hinduism found itself confronting a dynamic force animated by religious zeal in direct contradistinction to